▶ MADHYA PRADESH

TEARS IN THE SECULAR FABRIC

Even Hindus protest as Indore market imposes an exodus on Muslim employees

By **Rahul Noronha**

IF THE OLD TEXTILE METAPHOR FOR society is still valid, a century-old cloth market in Indore has torn the fabric a bit more. In the state's latest act of economic apartheid, 30-40 Muslim sales boys have been sacked by their Hindu employers and some traders expelled. All on the orders, say the victims and the Congress, of Eklavya Singh Gaur, son of Indore IV MLA Malini Gaur and Shivraj Chouhan-era minister, late Laxman Singh Gaur. The events cast a shadow on the festive season in the state's financial capital; the local administration is on the edge but silent.

THE DIKTAT

In a police complaint, district Congress chief Chintu Chauksey states Eklavya issued a diktat to Hindu shop-owners in Sheetlamata Market, which falls within Indore IV, to sack Muslim employees. Many shopkeepers obliged, others did not—those not complying are being threatened, says the complaint. A protest held by Muslim employees was supported by Hindus not agreeing with the termination. "I have been asked to vacate a cloth shop I co-own with my Hindu partner. I also vacated another shop after my landlord asked me to do so," says Mohammed Haroon, a shop keeper at the market.

The Gaurs neither deny nor accept the allegation, only cite 'love jihad'—attempts to contact Eklavya failed. Some hint it's part of the ceaseless theatre of one-upmanship in the local BJP. The Gaurs owe fealty to Chouhan. Ever since Gaur Sr died in an accident in 2008, Malini has won Indore IV; she was also mayor for a term. Under CM Mohan Yadav, they have been out of favour.

The BJP holds all nine seats in Indore district. Many of its top leaders are natives here, with state minister Kailash Vijayvargiya being a key player. Eklavya, says a senior local journalist, may well be trying to position himself as a Hindu *hriday samrat*—something amply rewarded in the new BJP. It's a crowded space. Golu Shukla, another local MLA, was heard warning parents on Dussehra to protect their kids from "jihadis lurking in gyms and in coaching class".

Eklavya's actions warrant an FIR, says Aminul Khan Suri of the Congress. "What he has demanded is plainly against the Constitution," he adds. Ex-CM Digvijaya Singh visited the Holkar-era market on September 27, but was not allowed to enter it, or even the Sheetla Mata temple nearby. ■

Takeaways

- **60-odd Muslim sales boys sacked by Hindu shopowners after 'ban'**
- **Festival season marred after diktat, alleged to be from local MLA's son**



ANI

▶ KERALA

TEMPLE GAT

Missing gold at Sabarimala, with a

By **Jeemon Jacob**

THE BANNER UNFURLED BY THE OPPOSITION in the Kerala assembly, during question hour on October 6, just about sums up the sordid controversy that has kept the state's media in a tizzy the past week or so. 'Ayyappan's gold stolen by *ambalam vizhungikal* (temple gobblers)', it said, not aiming for much subtlety. The dramatis personae of this low piece of drama apparently include Unnikrishnan Potti, a sometime junior priest at Sabarimala temple, one of the most popular (and richest) Hindu religious pilgrimage spots in south India.

The Travancore Devaswom Board (TDB), the quasi-autonomous body that manages the hilltop temple along with some 1,300 others in the state's southern parts, is not the only entity at the centre of what has become a whirlwind of allegations. The Pinarayi Vijayan-led